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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Johnson adds to team of lobbyists

Springfield alderwoman the second addition to group this month

By A.D. Quig, Jeremy Gorner and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Weeks after tapping a former Chicago alderman to help lobby for the city in the state capitol, Mayor Brandon Johnson is adding a Springfield alderwoman to his once-skeletal state team.

Johnson's office confirmed Thursday it intends to hire Lakeisha Purchase, a current Springfield alderwoman and registered state lobbyist, on a contract basis, saying



Purchase

she came "highly recommended from lawmakers in Springfield." Before she became a lobbyist, Purchase was employed as a support services specialist for the Illinois Department of Transportation, where she was once faulted for "abusing" government time. She left the IDOT job in 2023.

Purchase's hiring is part of a broader shift in Johnson's inter-governmental affairs efforts in Springfield, where since taking office nearly two years ago he's had minimal success working with Gov. JB Pritzker and some lawmakers. Johnson this month hired former Ald. John Arena, 45th, full time as one of his inter-governmental affairs deputies over the objections of some of Arena's former colleagues who clashed with Arena on the City Council.

Among the team's biggest priorities: securing additional funding for the Chicago Transit Authority, covering additional costs at Chicago Public Schools and finding fiscal help with the city's overall budget.

Purchase, who does business

Turn to Lobbyist, Page 4



Vice President JD Vance, center right, and second lady Usha Vance, center left, eat a meal with soldiers at Pituffik Space Base in Greenland on Friday.
JIM WATSON/AFP

Vance: Denmark putting Greenland security at risk

VP ramps up criticism as Trump continues talk of taking over island

By Philip Crowther, Kirsten Grieshaber and Aamer Madhani
Associated Press

NUUK, Greenland — Vice President JD Vance said on Friday that Denmark has "underinvested" in Greenland's security and demanded that Denmark change its approach as President Donald Trump continues to talk of taking over the Danish territory.

The pointed remarks came as Vance visited U.S. troops on Pituffik Space Base on the mineral rich, strategically critical island.

"Our message to Denmark is very simple: You have not done a

good job by the people of Greenland," Vance said. "You have underinvested in the people of Greenland, and you have underinvested in the security architecture of this incredible, beautiful land-mass filled with incredible people. That has to change."

Vance said the U.S. has "no option" but to take a significant position to ensure the security of Greenland as he encouraged a push in Greenland for independence from Denmark.

"I think that they ultimately will partner with the United States," Vance said. "We could make them much more secure. We could do a lot more protection. And I think

they'd fare a lot better economically as well."

Vance was joined by his wife and other senior U.S. officials as they visited an American military base in Greenland on Friday in a trip that was scaled back after an uproar among Greenlanders and Danes who were irked that the original itinerary was planned without consulting them.

Soon after arriving, Vance briefly addressed U.S. troops stationed at the base as he and his wife sat down to lunch with them, saying that the Republican administration of President Donald Trump is very interested in "Arctic security."

He and his entourage, including national security adviser Mike Waltz, Energy Secretary Chris Wright and Republican Sen. Mike Lee of Utah, then received briefings from military officials.

"As you all know, it's a big issue and it's only going to get bigger over the coming decades," Vance said at the start of his lunch with troops, noting that he was the first U.S. vice president to visit Greenland.

The revised trip to the semi-autonomous Danish territory comes as relations between the U.S. and the Nordic country have soured

Turn to Vance, Page 6



A person rides past Francis W. Parker School in Chicago in 2020. TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Assistant teachers, library assistants at Francis W. Parker School unionize

By Shanzeh Ahmad
Chicago Tribune

A majority of assistant teachers and library assistants at Francis W. Parker School announced their intention to unionize this week.

Eighty percent of the 30 assistant teachers and library assistants on staff filed paperwork expressing their intent to form a union with the Illinois Federation of Teachers, according to Lucy Wainger, an assistant teacher in a fifth grade classroom at Parker. The Lincoln Park-based school recognized the

effort on Thursday.

The school administration was notified with the hope that there would be a voluntary recognition of the union effort in order to proceed to collective bargaining, said Amy Excell, a spokesperson for the Illinois Federation of Teachers.

Nicole Tetreault, an assistant teacher in senior kindergarten, said a smaller group began working on this effort about six months ago before going public this week.

"We're super excited that the school recognized our union will-

ingly, and we're super excited to work with everybody and talk about ways that we can make this the best for our students and make sure that the conditions are great for the rest of the assistant teachers and library assistants," Tetreault said.

Daniel Frank, principal of Francis Parker, said in an email to the Tribune on Thursday, "Francis W. Parker School has enjoyed a good working relationship with the Illinois Federation of Teachers

Turn to Union, Page 2

Farmers aim to protect wetlands against lawsuit

Chicago investor, two law firms challenging Farm Bill provision

By Karina Atkins
Chicago Tribune

Several Iowa farmers have joined the federal government to defend a long-standing Farm Bill provision that protects wetlands against a challenge by a Chicago-based investor and two libertarian law firms.

A ruling against the defendants could endanger wetlands nationwide and upend how the government determines eligibility for federal programs. The parties head to a courthouse Monday in Cedar Rapids, Iowa.

In the upper Midwest, 30 million acres of wetlands, including over 640,000 in Iowa and 1 million in Illinois, are at risk of being destroyed by industrial agriculture, according to a study by the Union of Concerned Scientists.

The provision in question, colloquially known as Swampbuster, has discouraged farmers from turning wetlands into crop-

land since 1985. Under the law, any farmer who drains a wetland on their property is ineligible for federal benefits such as subsidies, loans and insurance.

Swampbuster protects about 78 million acres of wetlands, according to Food and Water Watch. That's two-thirds of the wetlands remaining in the continental United States after agriculture, development and climate change have cut their footprint in half since the 1780s.

These ecosystems serve as natural sponges and filters, absorbing excess water to prevent flooding and catching pollutants before they run into local waterways. Wetlands are also a critical habitat for a variety of plants and animals.

However, the plaintiffs, who filed the lawsuit last April in federal court in Iowa, argue that Swampbuster amounts to government overreach because it safeguards wetlands not protected under the Clean Water Act.

"Just because Congress couldn't directly regulate it, they

Turn to Farmers, Page 4

Christians, Muslims united in fasting

As Ramadan, which rotates around the calendar, coincides with Lent this year, people of alternate religions explain why they fast. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Deadly quake hits Myanmar, Thailand

A powerful earthquake destroyed buildings, bridges and a monastery and killed hundreds in the neighboring countries. **Nation & World**

